



▲ ROCK GUNNEL

A north Atlantic shore fish, the rock gunnel can survive among wet seaweed at low tide, but prefers a deep pool.

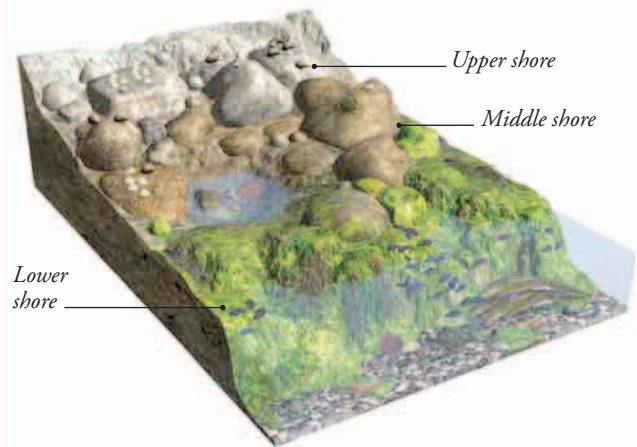
BACK TO BASE

Some tide-pool animals, including small shore fish, shrimp, and crabs, are mobile enough to leave the pool when the rising tide floods the shore. This enables the animals to look for food among the surrounding rocks. Most return to the pools as the tide begins to fall to avoid being stranded. But some, such as shore crabs, are able to find their way back even after the tide has gone out.



HIGH AND LOW

The richness of tide-pool life depends on the size of the pool and its position on the shore. Small pools may heat up or even freeze, so they are dangerous for marine animals. Pools on the upper shore are exposed for many hours, if not days, and may dry out or fill with rain. Big pools on the middle and lower shore are more like the open sea, and hold far more life.



STRANDED

Sometimes, animals turn up in tide pools that they would rather not be in. When hunting for food in open water near the shore at high tide, they can get left behind as the tide level falls. Some of these tide-pool visitors are big animals such as octopuses and lobsters. They have to wait until the next high tide gives them a means of escape.



▲ COMMON OCTOPUS

Found throughout the world, the common octopus hunts in shallow coastal seas and may get stranded in tide pools. Remarkably, it can change its color and patterns instantly in order to hide and blend in with its surroundings.